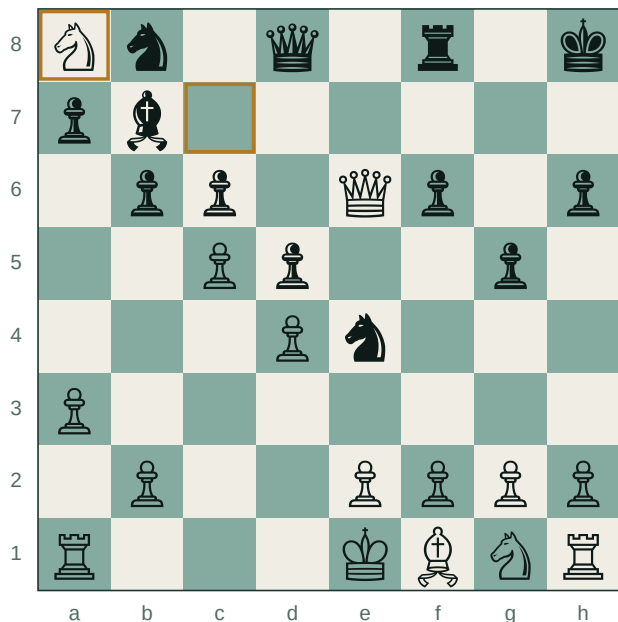


Trapping a piece: Black, move 17

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 17.Nxa8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17...Bc8 18. Qxc8 Qxc8

17...Bc8 The bishop moves from b7 to c8. Recorded reply: **18.Qxc8**.

18...Qxc8 The queen captures the queen on c8.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 27 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +6:** the balance goes from -6 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: knight on a8 and queen on e6. Check for tactical protection.